Service User Involvement & Advocacy Policy

Policy Title: Service User Involvement & Advocacy Policy

Effective Date: [Insert Date]

Review Date: [Insert Date – usually annually]

Version: 1.0

Applies to: All residents, staff, contractors, volunteers, and visitors at [INSERT CARE HOME NAME]

1. Policy Statement

At [INSERT CARE HOME NAME], we are committed to promoting the voice, choice, and rights of our residents. We believe that residents should be fully involved in decisions about their care, daily life, and the running of the service. Where residents need support to express their views, independent advocacy will be provided.

We aim to:

- Empower residents to participate actively in care planning and decision-making.
- Ensure residents have access to advocacy services when required.
- Create an open and inclusive culture where feedback shapes service delivery.
- Uphold the principles of dignity, independence, and respect.

2. Purpose

This policy ensures that:

- Residents are central to all decisions affecting them.
- Staff encourage and facilitate resident involvement in care and service development.
- Advocacy is available to protect residents' rights, especially when capacity or communication barriers exist.
- Compliance is maintained with the Care Act 2014, Mental Capacity Act 2005, and CQC Fundamental Standards.

3. Scope

This policy applies to:

- All residents at [INSERT CARE HOME NAME].
- All staff and volunteers supporting residents.
- Families, advocates, and external professionals engaged in care planning and decision-making.

4. Roles and Responsibilities

Registered Manager:

- Ensures advocacy is available and accessible to residents who need it.
- Oversees systems for resident involvement in decision-making and service improvement.
- Ensures staff training on advocacy and resident involvement.

All Staff:

- Promote residents' rights, choices, and involvement in all aspects of care.
- Support residents in accessing advocacy services.
- Encourage residents to express opinions, wishes, and feedback.

Residents:

- Are encouraged to participate in care planning, meetings, and service development activities.
- Have the right to request an advocate at any time.

Advocates:

- Represent the views, wishes, and interests of residents.
- Act independently and without conflict of interest.

5. Service User Involvement

Residents will be supported to be involved in:

- Individual Care Planning – residents participate in writing and reviewing their care plans.
- Daily Living – making choices about routines, activities, meals, and lifestyle.
- Service Development – resident meetings, surveys, and feedback forums to influence policies and practices.
- Recruitment – involvement in staff recruitment where appropriate.
- Quality Assurance – participation in audits, inspections, and satisfaction reviews.

6. Advocacy

- Residents have the right to an independent advocate if they have difficulty expressing their views or lack capacity for certain decisions.
- Advocacy will be provided in line with the Care Act 2014 and Mental Capacity Act 2005.
- Types of advocacy available include:
    - Independent Mental Capacity Advocates (IMCA)
    - Independent Mental Health Advocates (IMHA)
    - Care Act advocates
    - Generic advocacy services (community-based or specialist)
- The service will maintain information on local advocacy providers and support residents to access them.

7. Equality, Diversity, and Accessibility

- Residents will be supported in a way that recognises cultural, religious, communication, and accessibility needs.
- Accessible communication methods (Easy Read, large print, pictorial aids, interpreters) will be used where required.
- All residents will be given equal opportunities to be involved, regardless of age, ability, or background.

8. Training and Awareness

- All staff will receive training on advocacy, service user rights, and involvement in care planning.
- Refresher training will ensure staff remain confident in supporting residents to express their views.
- Staff will be made aware of local advocacy services and referral pathways.

9. Monitoring and Review

- Resident meetings and satisfaction surveys will be conducted regularly.
- Feedback will be recorded and used to improve services.
- Advocacy use and outcomes will be monitored to ensure effectiveness.
- This policy will be reviewed annually or sooner if guidance or legislation changes.

10. References

- Care Act 2014
- Mental Capacity Act 2005
- Health and Social Care Act 2008 (Regulated Activities) Regulations 2014
- CQC Fundamental Standards
- Human Rights Act 1998

11. Related Policies

- Mental Capacity Act & DoLS Policy
- Equality, Diversity & Inclusion Policy
- Compliments & Feedback Policy
- Safeguarding Adults Policy
- Quality Assurance & Audit Policy

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